M. Dalbert Ma

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Interests AI & Organizations, Human–AI Interaction, Organizational Design, Digital Strategy

Education

London Business School, PhD in Strategy & Entrepreneurship — 2027

IESE Business School, MSc in Management — 2020

Pompeu Fabra University, LLM in Law & Economics — 2019

University of York, BA in Philosophy, Politics & Economics — 2018

Job Market Paper

[1] **Ma, M.D.** The Organizational Tradeoff of AI Coordination: Evidence from a Container Port

Abstract: Since Simon (1947), theories of the firm have explained how limits on attention, memory, and computation constrain how much interdependent activity can be placed under common control. Artificial intelligence (AI) can relax these information-processing constraints by optimizing over states represented in its training data. I study these consequences at one of the largest container terminals in the world, where the same system dispatches an autonomous fleet through AI-dominant and mixed human-AI zones. Across 179,925 tasks over 364 days, AI-dominant zones move 11% more cargo per vehicle in ordinary operation, sustaining equivalent crane output with fewer vehicles through tighter coordination. Under recurrent mechanical faults, that advantage disappears: per-vehicle productivity is statistically indistinguishable across zones. AI-dominant zones lose crane output and carry delays for two hours; mixed zones absorb shocks within thirty minutes without output loss. During unprecedented geomagnetic storms, the ranking reverses: AI-dominant zones lift 13% less cargo per crane-hour than mixed zones. A model shows how unified coordination can compress the slack preserved by distributed actors, increasing steady-state productivity while amplifying shock propagation. AI can therefore push an organization beyond the coordination limits imposed by bounded actors while making that configuration more vulnerable to unfamiliar states.

- *Awards (2026):* AOM Robert J. Litschert Best Doctoral Student Paper Award; AOM STR Best Paper Award; William H. Newman Dissertation Award Finalist; SMS Best Paper Prize Nominee
- *Selected Presentations (2026):* Wharton WINDS, MIT Business Implications of GenAI, Columbia Business School ECDC, Duke Strategy PhD Conference, CCC, Harvard AI Institute OUI Conference, Academy of Management, Oxford ISA, Strategic Management Society

Working Papers

[2] Jacobides, M.G., **Ma, M.D.**, Das, A., Iyer, S., & Langione, M. Generative AI and the Architecture of Knowledge Work: Expertise Bypass, Exchange Governability, and Shifting Bottlenecks. ***Conditionally Accepted, Strategic Entrepreneurship Journal***

[3] Jacobides, M.G. & **Ma, M.D.** What Are Generative AI's Competitive Implications? A Longitudinal Documentation of Director Expectations. *Preparing for submission to Management Science*

[4] **Ma, M.D.**, Brahm, F., & Sun, S. The Value of Human-in-the-Loop: Evidence from Self-Driving Logistics. *Preparing for submission to Management Science*

[5] Jacobides, M.G. & **Ma, M.D.** Realizing Physical and Digital Synergies in Multi-Business Firms: A Configurational Approach. *Preparing for submission to Organization Science*

Work in Progress

[6] **Ma, M.D.** & Vakili, K. Generative AI and the Shifting Locus of Innovation: Start-ups, Incumbents, and Programming Consolidation. *Data analysis in progress; IEPC-funded.*

[7] **Ma, M.D.**, Puntoni, S., & Jacobides, M.G. Generative AI and Schumpeterian Competition: Shifting Logics in Technological Regimes. *Draft in preparation; Wharton AI & Analytics-funded.*

[8] McElheran, K. & **Ma, M.D.** Task Interdependence, Causal Ambiguity, and the Attribution of AI's Value: Evidence from a Team-Production Experiment. *In design; experimental platform built.*

[9] Clarke, R. & **Ma, M.D.** AI Agents and Entrepreneurial Performance: A National Rollout of an AI Operating System. *In design; implementation partner secured.*

[10] **Ma, M.D.**, Clarke, R., & Cheng, E.Y. Where Do Exceptions Go? Generative AI and Knowledge Hierarchies Inside Firms: Evidence from Enterprise Telemetry. *In design; data partnership secured.*

Practitioner Publications

[11] Jacobides, M.G., **Ma, M.D.**, Trantopoulos, K., & Vassalos, V. 2024. The Business Value of Gamification. *California Management Review.*

[12] Jacobides, M.G. & **Ma, M.D.** 2024. Assessing the Expected Impact of Generative AI on the UK Competitive Landscape. *UK Government Policy Report.*

[13] Jacobides, M.G., **Ma, M.D.**, Das, A., & Langione, M. 2026. Generative AI Is Not Just Changing Work. It Is Reallocating It. *Forbes.*

Symposia

Co-organizer, "Diversification in the Digital Age: Should We Rethink Our Premises?"
Strategic Management Society Annual Conference (October 2024).
With L. Capron, M.G. Jacobides, G. Lanzolla, C. Markides, P. Puranam, and Y. Romanenkov.

Co-organizer, "Opening the Black Box of Diversification: Mechanisms and Dynamics"
Academy of Management Annual Meeting (August 2024).
With C. Baldwin, C.E. Helfat, M.G. Jacobides, C. Magelssen, and J. Santalo.

Awards

Academy of Management Robert J. Litschert Best Doctoral Student Paper Award	2026
Academy of Management STR Division Best Paper Award	2026
Academy of Management William H. Newman Dissertation Award Finalist	2026
Strategic Management Society Best Paper Prize (Nominee)	2026
LBS Sir James Ball Award 25/26 (Runner-Up)	2025

Grants

Noorjehan Pirani PhD Fellowship Award, £10,000	2026
LBS Research & Materials Development Grant, £10,000	2026
Institute of Entrepreneurship and Private Capital Grant, £9,500	2024

Teaching

London Business School

Facilitator, Developing Strategy for Value Creation (EMBA)	2022–2026
Teaching Assistant, Profit, Power & Fairness in the Digital Economy (MBA)	2024–2026
Tutor, Next Generation Digital Strategy (EMBA)	2024–2025
Tutor, Aramco Executive Finance Strategy Programme (EMBA)	2025

Case Studies

Tanla & Indosat: Building an AI-Powered Shield Against a National Crisis, LBS 2026
Building the Phygital Ecosystem: The Journey of Majid Al Futtaim, LBS 2024
Facing the Retail Apocalypse: Majid Al Futtaim's Transformation, LBS 2024
HDFC ERGO: A Product Ecosystem Built on Mindshare, LBS 2024
From PingAn's Inspiration to HDFC ERGO's Journey, LBS 2024
From Products to Experience Ecosystems: Haier's Internet of Food, LBS 2022
Bridgewater Associates: Chasing Alpha, IESE 2022
Technical Note: Central Bank Digital Currencies, IESE 2022
Technical Note: Challenger Banks, IESE 2022

Service

Ad-hoc Reviewer: Industrial and Corporate Change, Long Range Planning
Conference Reviewer: AOM Annual Conference, Trans-Atlantic Doctoral Conference, LBS Ghoshal Conference, Strategic Management Society Annual Conference

Additional

Citizenship: USA
Languages: English, Mandarin, Spanish (Intermediate)

Skills

Computing: STATA, Python, R, MATLAB, BigQuery, LaTeX

References

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London Business School
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